point of view and finding money and finance to raise to fight an election.'

The Women's Reservation Act was still being debated in Parliament at the time that this BJP initiative focused on the 'basics in election management' with women leaders.[92] The Veerangana recruitment drive was run by the BJP's state youth units. Among those selected for the Delhi conclave, '90 per cent were rank newcomers who eventually became members of the party. Many of them became state-level leaders within the next decade.'[93] As a key organiser recalled, 'The outcome of doing such activity was so ecstatic that the party for the first time started taking notice of the under-thirty-five segment of women.'

The choice of name—Veerangana—drew on older Sangh traditions that valorise female nationalist warriors. 'It was chosen in a conversation with Sushma Swaraj because it had a "veer ras" [bravery element],' said Tikoo. 'The RSS already had [a] wing and there was a Durga Vahini. Veerangana is softer and we also attached it with Rani of Jhansi. It was a name of joy, not just a victory, but also of joy, of putting up a brave face. We often used to refer to Rani of Jhansi in our meetings and recited Subhadra Kumari Chauhan's famous poem, "*khoob larhee mardani voh toh Jhansi vaali rani thee* [how splendidly she fought, in a manly way, she was the queen of Jhansi]".'[94]

This tradition of focusing on veeranganas has since become a part of BJP Mahila Morcha events. In May 2018, for example, Prime Minister Modi, while addressing the Karnataka BJP Mahila Morcha workers on a live video chat, began his interaction by first paying homage to a range of female veeranaganas from the state: Kittur Rani Chennamma, Keladi Chenamma, Belawadi Mallamma, Rani Abbakka Chowta and the Chitradurga warrior Onake Obavya.[95] The BJP's 2018 training manual for women workers, in fact, has a whole section listing women heroes. Starting with Vedic sages like Gargi, Kapila, Arundhati, Maitreyi, and even Ayodhya's warrior queen Kaikeyi from the Ramayana, the list is long and religion-agnostic. It includes Rani Padmavati, who committed jauhar while resisting Sultan Alauddin Khilji's assault on Chittor; Razia Sultan, the first female sultan of Delhi; the Maratha hero Shivaji's mother, Jijabai; the